

The Deadly Beauty of the Box Jellyfish

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 6 English — Reading

ACARA v9.0: AC9E6LY03 / AC9E6LY05 / AC9E6LY06

Learning Intention

I am learning to analyse how an author uses evidence and text structures to inform and persuade the reader.

Success Criteria

- I can identify the author's purpose and key arguments.
- I can analyse how evidence supports the main ideas.
- I can evaluate the significance of information in the text.

The Deadly Beauty of the Box Jellyfish

Floating almost invisibly through the warm coastal waters of northern Australia is one of the most dangerous creatures in the ocean: the box jellyfish. Despite its delicate, almost ghostly appearance, this jellyfish is considered one of the most venomous marine animals on the planet.

Box jellyfish get their name from their distinctive cube-shaped bell, from which trail long, nearly transparent tentacles that can stretch up to three metres in length. Each tentacle is covered in millions of microscopic stinging cells called nematocysts, which fire venom into anything that brushes against them, often before a swimmer even realises they've been stung.

The venom of a box jellyfish attacks the heart, nervous system and skin cells simultaneously. In severe cases, a sting can cause cardiac arrest within minutes, making the box jellyfish responsible for more deaths in Australian waters than sharks, crocodiles and stonefish combined, according to some wildlife safety records.

Despite this danger, box jellyfish are not aggressive by nature. They do not hunt or attack humans deliberately; stings almost always happen accidentally, when a swimmer brushes against trailing tentacles that are extremely difficult to see in the water. This is one key reason authorities place close nets and warning signs at many popular beaches in northern Australia during "jellyfish season," which typically runs from October to May.

If a sting does occur, immediate first aid is critical: vinegar is poured over the sting site to stop unfired nematocysts from releasing more venom, and emergency medical help must be sought immediately. With fast treatment, most stings — while extremely painful — are survivable.

Understanding the box jellyfish is not about fear alone, but about respect. Like many of nature's most dangerous creatures, the box jellyfish plays an important role in its ecosystem, and swimmers who follow safety advice can enjoy Australia's tropical waters while minimising the very real risk this remarkable animal presents.

Part A — Comprehension Questions

Q1. Where does the box jellyfish typically live? _____

Q2. What are the microscopic stinging cells on a jellyfish's tentacles called? _____

Q3. True or False: Box jellyfish deliberately hunt and attack humans. _____

Q4. What months does 'jellyfish season' typically run from, according to the text?

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Part B — More Comprehension Questions

Q5. What immediate first aid step is described for a box jellyfish sting?

Q6. What 3 body systems does the venom attack simultaneously?

Q7. According to the text, how does the danger of box jellyfish compare to sharks, crocodiles and stonefish?

Part C — Challenge: Think Deeper

A local council is deciding whether to close a popular northern Australian beach entirely during jellyfish season, rather than just posting warning signs and nets.

Q8. Using evidence from the text, explain one argument for and one argument against closing the beach completely.

Q9. Explain why the author titled the text 'The Deadly Beauty' rather than simply 'The Dangerous Jellyfish.' What effect does this have on the reader?

Q10. Evaluate the author's final claim that understanding the box jellyfish is 'not about fear alone, but about respect.' Do you find this a convincing way to end the text? Justify your answer using evidence and structure from the text.

Answer Key — Part A & B

A1: In the warm coastal waters of northern Australia.

A2: Nematocysts.

A3: False — box jellyfish are not aggressive and do not deliberately hunt or attack humans.

A4: October to May.

A5: Vinegar is poured over the sting site to stop unfired nematocysts from releasing more venom.

A6: The heart, nervous system and skin cells.

A7: Box jellyfish are responsible for more deaths in Australian waters than sharks, crocodiles and stonefish combined, according to some wildlife safety records.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: For: closing the beach would remove risk entirely during the most dangerous season. Against: the text notes stings are accidental and largely preventable with nets, signs and fast first aid, so full closure may be an extreme response when safer swimming is still possible with precautions (accept similar reasonable points).

C9: The title 'The Deadly Beauty' captures both the jellyfish's delicate, almost graceful appearance and its extreme danger in just a few words, creating intrigue and reflecting the text's balanced message of danger and respect, more effectively than a plain, purely factual title.

C10: Accept a reasoned answer, as long as it references how the text builds from danger/facts toward a balanced, respectful conclusion, and evaluates whether this shift in tone effectively changes how the reader feels about the animal by the end — teacher to check reasoning quality.